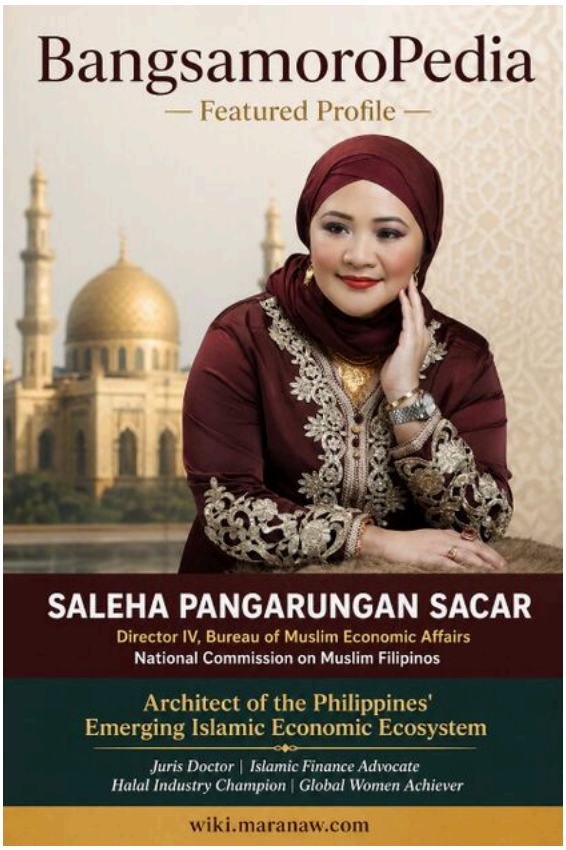
Saleha Pangarungan Sacar

Saleha Pangarungan Sacar is a Filipino Juris Doctor, distinguished public servant, and development leader who currently serves as Director IV of the Bureau of Muslim Economic Affairs (BMEA) at the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF). Born in Saudi Arabia as a natural-born Filipino citizen, Sacar has emerged as one of the country's most influential voices in Islamic finance, halal industry development, and inclusive economic policy—earning recognition as a key architect of the Philippines' emerging Islamic economic ecosystem. Her groundbreaking work in diplomacy, governance, Islamic banking and finance, and halal industry development has positioned her at the forefront of advancing inclusive, ethical, and sustainable economic systems for Muslim Filipinos and the broader national economy. With a career defined by bridging policy, finance, and industry development, Sacar stands as a trailblazer whose leadership in the 5th International Islamic Finance Conference and sustained advocacy for the halal industry demonstrate a cohesive strategy that integrates economic development with cultural and religious values. A recipient of numerous international accolades—including the Excellence in Public Service and Humanitarian Award of the Year 2025, Most Outstanding Woman in Public Service 2025, and multiple Global Women Achiever awards—Sacar represents a new generation of Filipino Muslim leaders whose work not only uplifts Muslim Filipino communities but also contributes to a broader national vision of a more inclusive, ethical, and globally competitive Philippine economy.

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Saleha Pangarungan Sacar



Director IV	
Incumbent	**Bureau of Muslim Economic Affairs** National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
Assumed office	February 6, 2020
Personal details	
Born	Saleha Pangarungan Sacar Saudi Arabia
Citizenship	Filipino (Natural-born)
Education	**Mindanao State University** (BS Public Administration) **Philippine Law School** (Juris Doctor) **University of Perpetual Help System Dalta** (MPA, DPA candidate)
Occupation	Public servant, development leader

Early Life and Background

Saleha Pangarungan Sacar was born in Saudi Arabia to Filipino parents, making her a natural-born Filipino citizen with deep cultural ties to both the Middle East and the Philippines. Growing up with exposure to Islamic governance and finance systems in Saudi Arabia while maintaining strong connections to her Filipino heritage shaped her unique perspective on economic development and public service. This bicultural upbringing would later prove instrumental in her ability to bridge Western governance frameworks with Islamic economic principles, positioning her as an effective advocate for Muslim Filipino communities within the Philippine government system. Her early exposure to Islamic banking practices and halal industry standards in Saudi Arabia provided foundational knowledge that would become central to her professional mission of establishing robust Islamic economic infrastructure in the Philippines.

Education

Sacar's educational journey reflects a deliberate progression from public administration fundamentals to specialized legal training and advanced governance studies. She began her tertiary education at Mindanao State University, where she earned a Bachelor of Science in Public Administration from June 2000 to October 2005. This foundational training in governance, policy analysis, and administrative systems provided her with essential frameworks for understanding how government institutions serve diverse populations.

Recognizing the critical importance of legal expertise in policy advocacy and institutional reform, Sacar pursued her Juris Doctor degree at the Philippine Law School from October 2006 to March 2012. This legal training equipped her with the analytical skills and regulatory knowledge necessary to navigate complex legislative environments and advocate for policy changes affecting Muslim Filipino communities. Her legal background has proven particularly valuable in her work on Islamic banking regulations, halal certification frameworks, and economic rights advocacy.

Building on her practical experience in government service, Sacar pursued a Master's in Public Administration at the University of Perpetual Help System Dalta from November 2020 to May 2022. This advanced degree deepened her understanding of public sector management, strategic planning, and policy implementation. Currently, she is pursuing a Doctor of Public Administration at the same institution, demonstrating her commitment to continuous learning and her aspiration to contribute scholarly research to the field of public governance and Islamic economic development.

Her educational background is further strengthened by specialized training programs that have enhanced her professional capabilities. She completed the 17th Shariah Training Course conducted by the Supreme Court of the Philippines in partnership with NCMF, which deepened her understanding of Islamic jurisprudence and its application in Philippine legal contexts. She also received Best Diplomat training in Diplomacy and Leadership from UNITAR, participated in Islamic Banking and Finance training programs offered by the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas (BSP), and completed various training courses on supervisory and managerial skills. Additionally, she has developed technical competencies in graphics design and Microsoft Office applications, demonstrating versatility that extends beyond traditional governance training.

Career

Sacar's career trajectory reflects a strategic progression from legal practice to executive leadership in Muslim economic affairs, with each role building on previous experiences to culminate in her current influential position.

Legal Practice and Early Government Service

Following her admission to the bar, Sacar served as Attorney 1 at the Bureau of Legal Affairs within the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos from February 1, 2019, to January 30, 2020. In this capacity, she provided legal counsel on matters affecting Muslim Filipino rights, reviewed legislative proposals, and contributed to the development of legal frameworks supporting Islamic institutions in the Philippines. This role gave her firsthand insight into the legal barriers facing Muslim Filipino communities and the regulatory gaps that needed to be addressed to support Islamic economic activities.

Private Sector Leadership

Before joining NCMF in a legal capacity, Sacar gained valuable private sector experience as Chief Executive Officer and President of Arphil International Corporation from May 30, 2012, to June 23, 2018. This six-year tenure in corporate leadership provided her with practical insights into business operations, international commerce, and private sector challenges that would later inform her public policy work. Her experience bridging public service and private enterprise has proven valuable in her current role, where she works to create enabling environments for Muslim Filipino businesses and halal industry entrepreneurs.

Director IV, Bureau of Muslim Economic Affairs

Since February 6, 2020, Sacar has served as Director IV of the Bureau of Muslim Economic Affairs at the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos—a position that has allowed her to translate her vision for inclusive Islamic economic development into concrete policies and programs. In this role, she leads strategic initiatives to advance Islamic banking and finance, expand halal industry development, and create economic opportunities for Muslim Filipino communities across the country.

Her leadership extends to her role as Chairman of the Regional Halal Programs Management Committee within NCMF, where she coordinates efforts to strengthen halal certification systems, support halal entrepreneurs, and position the Philippines as a competitive player in the global halal market. Under her guidance, NCMF has strengthened partnerships with Islamic financial institutions, developed training programs for halal industry stakeholders, and advocated for policy reforms that recognize and accommodate Islamic economic principles within the Philippine regulatory framework.

Institutional Contributions and Advocacy

Sacar's most significant contributions lie in her strategic vision for building comprehensive Islamic economic infrastructure that serves both Muslim Filipino communities and the broader Philippine economy. Her work transcends traditional administrative functions to encompass policy advocacy, international diplomacy, industry development, and grassroots capacity building.

Islamic Finance and Banking Advocacy

One of Sacar's primary advocacy areas is the expansion and institutionalization of Islamic banking and finance in the Philippines. Recognizing that conventional banking systems often fail to meet the religious requirements of Muslim Filipinos, she has worked tirelessly to promote Shariah-compliant financial products and services. Her advocacy has focused on creating regulatory frameworks that accommodate Islamic banking principles while ensuring compliance with Philippine banking standards—a delicate balance that requires both legal expertise and cultural sensitivity.

Through her work with the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas and collaboration with Islamic financial institutions, Sacar has contributed to expanding access to halal financial services, promoting financial inclusion for Muslim communities, and positioning the Philippines as an emerging hub for Islamic finance in Southeast Asia. Her efforts align with broader regional trends toward Islamic financial integration while respecting local contexts and regulatory requirements.

Halal Industry Development

Sacar has been a driving force behind efforts to develop and professionalize the Philippines' halal industry. She recognizes that the global halal market represents a significant economic opportunity for Filipino Muslim entrepreneurs and that establishing robust halal certification systems can open export markets while creating jobs in Muslim-majority regions. Her work in this area has included developing training programs for halal certifiers, strengthening quality assurance mechanisms, promoting halal entrepreneurship, and advocating for government support for halal industry development.

Her leadership in organizing and participating in the 5th International Islamic Finance Conference demonstrates her commitment to positioning the Philippines within global Islamic economic networks. By facilitating knowledge exchange, attracting international investment, and showcasing Filipino Muslim economic initiatives, she has helped elevate the country's profile in the Islamic economic sphere.

Policy Integration and Sustainable Development

What distinguishes Sacar's approach is her holistic vision that integrates Islamic economic principles with broader goals of sustainable development, ethical business practices, and inclusive growth. Rather than treating Islamic finance and halal industry development as niche sectors serving only Muslim communities, she frames these initiatives as contributions to national economic competitiveness and alignment with global trends toward ethical and values-based economic systems.

Her work demonstrates how culturally sensitive economic policies can serve both specific communities and broader national interests—creating models for inclusive development that respect religious and cultural diversity while advancing shared economic goals. This integrative approach positions her as a bridge-builder who can navigate between different stakeholder groups and articulate shared interests across religious and cultural lines.

Leadership and Recognition

Sacar's contributions have garnered extensive recognition both domestically and internationally, establishing her as one of the most decorated Filipino public servants of her generation.

Her awards and recognitions include the Excellence in Public Service and Humanitarian Award of the Year 2025 from the Global Excellence Leadership Award, Most Outstanding Woman in Public Service 2025 from the Rotary Club of San Francisco Del Monte, and Upholder of Halal Excellence Award 2025 from the Prime Group of Companies held in Dubai, UAE. She was named Premier Achiever Outstanding Public Servant of the Year 2024 by the Southeast Asian Premier Business and Achiever Award, and received multiple Empowered Female Advocate for Muslim and Humanitarian Affairs awards in 2024 and 2023 from various international organizations.

Additional honors include National Outstanding Women of Achievements in the Field of Public Service of the Year 2024 from the 2024 Greater Good Achievers Leadership Awards, Dynamic Female Leader Award 2024 from PRIME GROUP held in Dubai, and Global Women Achiever recognition in 2024, 2023, and 2022 from the World

Women Leadership Congress and Awards. She was recognized as Asia's Empowered Female Advocate for Muslim and Humanitarian Affairs 2023 by Asia's Golden Icon Awards and the Kasosyo Summit Committee.

She has also received recognition as Heroes' Notable Female Leader and Advocate for Muslim Filipinos 2023 from Asia's Modern Hero Awards, Asia's most distinguished female public servant for Muslim Filipinos from Asia's Pinnacle Awards, and Asia's Woman Leader 2022 from the World Women Leadership Organization. The Bangsamoro Transition Authority passed BTA Resolution No. 254 congratulating Sacar as a recipient of the 9th World Woman Leadership Congress, and she was honored as Galing Pinas PEZA Investment and Promotion Awardee 2021.

Beyond governmental awards, Sacar serves as Club President of the Rotary Club of Diliman International, Rotary District 3780, Rotary International for Rotary Year 2024-2025—a role that reflects her commitment to community service and humanitarian causes beyond her official government duties.

Personal Life and Interests

Outside her professional achievements, Sacar maintains active interests in athletics and endurance sports, particularly marathon running and triathlon competitions. These pursuits reflect her disciplined approach to personal development and her commitment to maintaining physical and mental resilience—qualities that serve her well in the demanding environment of public service and advocacy.

Her athletic endeavors also symbolize her broader philosophy of pushing boundaries and demonstrating that Muslim Filipino women can excel across multiple domains—from legal practice and government leadership to competitive sports—challenging stereotypes and inspiring younger generations.

Legacy and Impact

Saleha Pangarungan Sacar's legacy lies in her role as a pioneering architect of the Philippines' Islamic economic infrastructure and her demonstration of how culturally grounded public service can advance both community-specific needs and broader national interests. Her work has fundamentally shifted how the Philippine government approaches Muslim economic affairs—moving from symbolic representation to substantive policy development and institutional capacity building.

By establishing frameworks for Islamic banking, professionalizing the halal industry, and positioning Filipino Muslim economic initiatives within global networks, Sacar has created institutional foundations that will continue to generate opportunities long after her tenure. Her leadership model—combining legal expertise, diplomatic skill, private sector experience, and deep cultural understanding—provides a blueprint for effective advocacy in multicultural democracies.

Perhaps most significantly, Sacar represents a visible counter-narrative to deficit-based portrayals of Muslim Filipino communities. Her international recognition, professional excellence, and values-based leadership demonstrate the contributions that Filipino Muslims make to national development and global Islamic economic systems. For young Muslim Filipino women, her career trajectory offers proof that they can aspire to the highest levels of professional achievement while maintaining strong religious and cultural identities.

As the Philippines continues to navigate questions of economic inclusion, religious accommodation, and cultural diversity, Sacar's integrated approach to policy development offers valuable lessons. Her work demonstrates that economic systems can be both culturally sensitive and globally competitive, that religious values can align with

ethical business practices, and that serving specific communities can contribute to broader national progress. In this sense, her legacy extends beyond specific policies or programs to encompass a vision of inclusive development that the Philippines—and other diverse democracies—can build upon for generations to come.

External Links

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos Official Website (https://www.ncmf.gov.ph)
- Profile provided by Mimi Manabilang (https://www.facebook.com/mimi.manabilang)

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